About The Author

Edwin Muir (1887-1959) was a renowned Scottish poet, novelist, translator and critic. He was remembered for his vivid poetry. He began writing poetry at a relatively old age, and over the course of several years worked out an individual, philosophical style for which he gained recognition later in his life. First Poems and Chorus of the Newly Dead contain Muir's initial attempts. Muir's later collections include Variations on a Time Theme, The Narrow Place, The Voyage and Other Poems, The Labyrinth, and One Foot in Eden.

Glossary

turret wall	-	a small tower on top of a castle
mowers	-	people who trim grass and level the lawns
provender	-	food
towering battlements	-	tall towers with openings to shoot the enemies
tier	-	one above the other
friendly allies	-	helpful or supporting nations or armed forces
foothold	-	advantageous position
quick	-	alive
bait	-	something intended to entice someone to do something
wicked	-	evil or morally wrong
wicket gate	-	a small gate
wizened warder	-	an aged or old guard
maze	-	a winding , intricate confusing path
treacherous	-	disloyal
groan	-	lament, cry
citadel	-	a safe and strong fort
overthrown	-	conquered, defeated
maintain	-	believe

1. Based on your understanding of the poem, answer the following questions in one or two sentences each.

a) Who is the narrator in the poem?

b) How long had the soldiers been in the castle?

c) Why were the soldiers in the castle fearless?

d) Where were the enemies?

e) Why does the narrator say that the enemy was no threat at all?

f) Did the soldiers fight with the enemies face to face?

g) Who had let the enemies in?

h) How did the enemies enter the castle?

i) Why were the secret galleries bare?

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